CHAPTER 3

CONTEMPORARY SOUTH ASIA

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Explore the geopolitical landscape of South Asia, examining the domestic struggles between democracy and military dominance in Pakistan, the liberation and democratic consolidation of Bangladesh, Nepal's transition to a republic, ethnic conflict in Sri Lanka, bilateral disputes, and regional integration through SAARC.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Democratic Fragility in Pakistan:** Frequent cycles of elected civilian governance interspersed with military takeovers (Ayub Khan, Yahya Khan, Zia-ul-Haq, Pervez Musharraf) stemming from the dominance of military, landowning elites, and clergy.

• **Liberation and Transformation of Bangladesh:** Sparked by cultural and economic neglect of East Pakistan, the 1970 electoral sweep by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Awami League led to Pakistani military atrocities, mass refugee displacement, and India's intervention in December 1971.

• **Constitutional Evolution of Nepal:** Progressed from absolute monarchy through a Maoist armed rebellion and the peaceful mass uprising of the Seven Party Alliance in April 2006, culminating in the adoption of a secular, federal democratic constitution in 2015.

• **Sri Lankan Ethnic Reconciliation:** Decades of violent insurgency led by the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) against the Sinhalese majority ended militarily in 2009, with challenges of political devolution remaining despite strong human development indicators.

ESSENTIAL CONSTITUTIONAL ARTICLES & THEORIES

$$\text{SAARC Framework (1985)} \iff \text{7 Founding Nations} \to \text{SAFTA Free Trade Agreement (2004)}$$

Institutional Architecture of South Asian Regional Cooperation

$$\text{Indus Waters Treaty (1960)} \iff \frac{\text{Eastern Rivers: Ravi, Beas, Sutlej (India)}}{\text{Western Rivers: Indus, Jhelum, Chenab (Pakistan)}}$$

World Bank Mediated Riparian Water Allocation Framework

$$\text{Bangladesh Liberation (1971)} \iff \text{Language Movement} + \text{Awami League Mandate} \to \text{Sovereign Republic}$$

Decolonisation and State Formation in East Bengal

$$\text{Nepal Democratic Transition} \iff \text{Absolute Monarchy} \longrightarrow \text{Seven Party Alliance (2006)} \longrightarrow \text{Federal Democratic Republic}$$

Sequence of Monarchical Abolition and Republican Democracy

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Do not state that SAARC began with eight members; Afghanistan joined as the eighth member in 2007 at the 14th SAARC Summit in New Delhi.

• **Alert:** Remember that the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960 was mediated by the World Bank and has endured through all Indo-Pakistani wars.

• **Alert:** Avoid confusing the Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF) timeline; it operated in Sri Lanka from 1987 until its withdrawal in 1990 without achieving total disarming of the LTTE.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Name the seven founding member nations of SAARC formed in 1985 and mention which country joined as the eighth member in 2007. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Founding Seven Members:** India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives. **[1 Mark]**

• **Eighth Member:** Afghanistan joined as the eighth member during the New Delhi Summit in 2007. **[1 Mark]**

2. What was the Indus Waters Treaty of 1960? Name the international financial institution that successfully mediated it. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Treaty Scope:** A historic water-distribution treaty signed by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and President Ayub Khan allocating the use of waters of the Indus river basin between India and Pakistan. **[1 Mark]**

• **Mediating Institution:** Mediated and facilitated by the World Bank (IBRD). **[1 Mark]**

3. Explain three primary factors that have prevented the consolidation of stable democracy in Pakistan. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Social Dominance of Military and Landlords:** The military elite, aristocracy, and orthodox religious clergy have maintained widespread social control, repeatedly overthrowing elected civilian governments. **[1 Mark]**

• **Geopolitical Exploitation by Superpowers:** Military regimes received external arms and financial aid during global conflicts, insulating military dictators from democratic accountability. **[1 Mark]**

• **Weak Civilian Institutions and Conflict with India:** The persistent confrontation with India was leveraged by military commanders to justify defense supremacy and suppress democratic protests. **[1 Mark]**

4. Describe the historical events that led to the independence and liberation of Bangladesh in 1971. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Cultural and Political Oppression:** Bengali citizens in East Pakistan faced linguistic discrimination, imposition of Urdu, and denial of equitable economic and political representation. **[1 Mark]**

• **1970 Democratic Mandate:** Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Awami League won an outright majority in the Pakistani parliament, but military rulers refused to convene the assembly and arrested him. **[1 Mark]**

• **Military Crackdown and Liberation War:** Pakistani army launched Operation Searchlight, causing mass massacres and driving 10 million refugees into India, culminating in India's military intervention and the surrender of Pakistani forces on 16 December 1971. **[1 Mark]**

5. Trace the democratic struggle that transformed Nepal from an absolute monarchy into a federal democratic republic. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Pro-Democracy Movements:** Nepal saw democratic protests in 1990 yielding a constitutional monarchy, but King Gyanendra dismissed parliament in 2002, assuming autocratic powers. **[1 Mark]**

• **Mass Mobilization of 2006:** The Seven Party Alliance (SPA) joined hands with Maoist insurgents to launch massive peaceful nationwide demonstrations in April 2006, forcing the King to restore parliament. **[1 Mark]**

• **Abolition of Monarchy and New Constitution:** The monarchy was formally abolished in 2008, and in 2015 Nepal adopted a comprehensive secular, federal democratic republican constitution. **[1 Mark]**

6. Examine the roots of the ethnic conflict in Sri Lanka and evaluate the intervention of the Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF). **[Score: 4 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Roots of Conflict:** After independence in 1948, politics was dominated by the Sinhalese majority, marginalizing the Sri Lankan Tamil minority through discriminatory language and educational policies. **[1 Mark]**

• **Armed Insurgency:** Tamil militancy solidified under the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), demanding a separate independent state (Tamil Eelam) in northeastern Sri Lanka. **[1 Mark]**

• **Indo-Sri Lanka Accord and IPKF:** India signed an accord with Sri Lanka in 1987, deploying the IPKF to disarm militants, but became embroiled in combat against the LTTE. **[1 Mark]**

• **Withdrawal and Final Defeat:** Facing opposition from both the Sri Lankan government and local Tamils, the IPKF was pulled out in 1990; the war ended militarily in May 2009 with the defeat of the LTTE. **[1 Mark]**

7. Evaluate the achievements and limitations of the South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA) agreement. **[Score: 3 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Objective of SAFTA:** Signed at the 12th SAARC Summit in Islamabad in 2004, SAFTA came into force on 1 January 2006 to lower trade tariffs and create a free trade zone across South Asia. **[1 Mark]**

• **Achievement:** Provided a negotiated multilateral platform for gradual tariff reduction and encouraged bilateral trade pacts between India and neighbours like Sri Lanka and Nepal. **[1 Mark]**

• **Limitation:** Deep political distrust between India and Pakistan, long negative lists of protected goods, and fear among smaller states of Indian industrial dominance have restricted its full potential. **[1 Mark]**